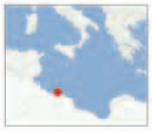
# THE UNITED STATES AT WAR

**DURING THE OPENING DECADES** of the 19th century, the United States fought a major war against Britain and two lesser conflicts against the Barbary pirates. These wars had in common a concern to maintain the freedom of the seas. The Barbary pirates were the naval forces of rogue North African Muslim states that preyed upon shipping in the Mediterranean. The United States was one of the countries that paid protection money to these states until President Thomas Jefferson threw doubt upon the practice, provoking Tripoli to declare war on America in 1801. An American squadron fought Tripoli until a compromise was reached in 1805, but a second round in 1815 was required to finish off the pirate menace. The war with Britain was largely the result of the high-handed actions of the Royal Navy during the Napoleonic Wars. When the conflict began the United States had 17 warships to Britain's 719. The Americans distinguished themselves in battles on Lake Erie and Lake Champlain and in frigate actions at sea, although the Royal Navy was able to blockade the American coast, burn Washington, and bombard Baltimore.



FIRST BARBARY WAR

## TRIPOLI HARBOR



**Date** August 3, 1804
**Forces** Americans: 1 frigate, 6 gunboats, 2 bomb-ketches; Libyans: 11 gunboats
**Losses** Americans: none; Libyans: 3 boats sunk, 3 captured

**Location** Tripoli harbor, Libya

In June 1803, Commodore Edward Preble was put in command of the squadron of ships sent by the United States to the Mediterranean to deal with the problem of piracy promoted by North African Barbary states. Where previous US naval commanders had concentrated on protecting American ships, Preble was determined to take the fight to the most obdurate of the pirate cities, Tripoli, which had declared war on the United States.

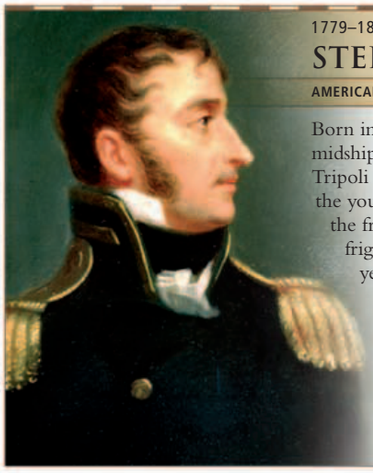
In the fall an American frigate, *Philadelphia*, ran aground off Tripoli while in hot pursuit of two pirate ships. It was captured and taken into the harbor for use as a floating battery. On February 16, 1804, a young lieutenant, Stephen Decatur, took a raiding party into the harbor at night and stormed *Philadelphia*, setting it ablaze so that it could be of no further use to the enemy. This action, hailed by Lord Nelson as "the most bold and daring act of the age," made Decatur an American national hero.

On August 3, 1804, Preble launched his most determined assault on Tripoli. He sent Decatur, now a captain, with a small force of gunboats and bomb-ketches (borrowed from the Bourbon Kingdom of the Two Sicilies) to enter the shallow waters of the harbor, while the frigate *Constitution* bombarded Tripoli's shore batteries and castle at long range. In the event only three of Decatur's six gunboats succeeded in entering the harbor, where they were met by 11 Tripolitan gunboats. Fierce hand-to-hand fighting developed as boats were boarded. Decatur was fortunate to escape with his life. The Libyans suffered by far the heavier losses, but no decisive advantage was gained and the blockade and occasional bombardment of the port continued.

An end to the conflict came in 1805 after US Marines were put ashore to threaten Tripoli by land. A compromise agreement saw the United States pay $60,000 for the release of all hostages.



**Close-quarters fight**
During the fight in Tripoli harbor, Decatur shot a Libyan in the back with a pistol, the spent ball lodging in the American captain's clothes.



1779–1820

### STEPHEN DECATUR

AMERICAN NAVAL COMMANDER

Born in Maryland, Decatur became a naval midshipman in 1798. After his bold action in Tripoli Harbor in 1804 he was made a captain, the youngest ever in the US Navy. Commanding the frigate *United States*, he captured the British frigate *Macedonian* in October 1812. Three years later, as commodore of a squadron in the West Indies, he was overcome by a British force and taken prisoner. After the war he commanded the American Mediterranean squadron and secured a final peace treaty with the Barbary pirates. He was killed in a duel with Commodore James Barron.

WAR OF 1812

## CONSTITUTION VS GUERRIERE



**Date** August 19, 1812
**Forces** Americans: 1 frigate; British: 1 frigate
**Losses** Americans: none; British: 1 frigate

**Location** Off Halifax, Nova Scotia

Early in the War of 1812, on August 2, 1812, Captain Isaac Hull took the American heavy frigate *Constitution* out of Boston to harass British shipping around the Gulf of St. Lawrence. Seventeen days later, sailing back southward, he ran into the smaller 38-gun British frigate *Guerriere*. With full confidence in British naval superiority, *Guerriere*'s captain, James Dacres, was happy to fight, even though *Constitution* mounted 52 guns and had 476 men on board to the British frigate's 280.

The *Guerriere* opened fire first, but her solid shot bounced off *Constitution*'s live oak hull—earning the American frigate the nickname "Old Ironsides." When the two ships came to close action, *Guerriere*'s mizzen mast was quickly brought down, lying over the side of the ship. Partially out of control, the British frigate was raked by the American heavy guns and her deck swept by grapeshot. The *Guerriere*'s fallen mizzen mast snagged on *Constitution* and the two ships tangled together but, despite their greater numbers, the Americans failed to board, driven back by British musket fire. Casualties were heavier on *Guerriere*'s decks, however, with Dacres among those wounded by American musketry.

When the ships eventually broke apart, *Guerriere* lost its other two masts and lay a defenseless hulk. Dacres struck to avoid further loss of life. The ship was too badly damaged to be saved and the Americans scuttled it the following morning.



**Victory medal**
This medal, commemorating the battle, shows a starboard-quarter view of the *Guerriere* dismasted (left), and a port broadside view of the *Constitution* firing (right).